

Wildfire Smoke: breathe safe, help others

Wildfire smoke carries tiny particles. They can enter your lungs and bloodstream. Much smoke exposure can be reduced. The two things that matter most: **check air quality** and **reduce smoke exposure indoors and out**.

MEDICAL EMERGENCY

Smoke can trigger life-threatening reactions

Call your local emergency number **immediately** if someone has chest pain, severe shortness of breath, confusion, or blue lips or fingernails. People with asthma or COPD should follow their emergency action plan. Seek care if rescue inhalers do not help.

Air Quality Index — know the colors

The AQI tells you how dangerous the air is right now. Check an official local air-quality source when you can. In the U.S., use **AirNow.gov**. Elsewhere, use your national or regional environment agency, or a trusted local weather alert service.

0–50 GREEN

Good

Air quality is fine. Normal activities are safe for most people.

51–100 YELLOW

Moderate

People unusually sensitive to smoke should consider reducing long outdoor exertion. This includes children, older adults, and people with asthma, COPD, or heart disease.

101–150 ORANGE

Unhealthy for sensitive groups

Sensitive groups should avoid long or heavy outdoor exertion. Everyone else should consider reducing it, especially if symptoms appear.

151–200 RED

Unhealthy

Everyone should avoid prolonged exertion outdoors. Sensitive groups should stay inside.

201–300 PURPLE**Very unhealthy**

Everyone should reduce activity. Stay indoors in cleaner air if possible. Keep windows closed unless indoor heat creates a bigger immediate danger.

301+ MAROON**Hazardous**

Emergency conditions. Avoid outdoor exertion. If you must go out and can wear one safely, use a well-fitting N95, KN95, or P100 respirator.

Who is most at risk?

- Children and teenagers (lungs still developing)
- Adults 65 and older
- Pregnant people
- People with asthma, COPD, or other lung diseases
- People with heart disease or diabetes
- Outdoor workers
- People experiencing homelessness or without reliable shelter

Protect yourself and others

- 1 **Check the AQI every morning** during wildfire season. Set alerts on AirNow or your weather app.
- 2 **Stay indoors in cleaner air** when smoke is unhealthy. Keep windows and doors closed unless indoor heat or another hazard makes that unsafe.
- 3 **Create a clean-air room.** Choose an inside room with few windows. Run an air purifier continuously. Avoid candles, frying, vacuuming, or gas stoves without ventilation.
- 4 **Wear a well-fitting N95, KN95, or P100 respirator** if you must go outside in unhealthy smoke and can wear one safely. Cloth masks do not reliably block PM2.5. Respirators may not fit infants or young children. They may also be hard for some people with breathing conditions.
- 5 **Consider a Corsi-Rosenthal box.** This DIY air cleaner uses a box fan and MERV-13 or better filters. It can reduce indoor particle levels when built and used correctly. Follow current build and electrical-safety guidance. Use newer, safety-certified fans where possible. Do not block exits or create trip hazards.
- 6 **Check on neighbors at higher risk daily.** Offer masks, a ride to a clean-air shelter, or help running a filter.
- 7 **Reduce or cancel outdoor events** when AQI is over 150.

For community organizers

ACTION CHECKLIST

- Identify or coordinate **clean-air spaces**. Use HEPA filtration, safe DIY air cleaners, or other verified filtration.
- **Distribute well-fitting respirators** to outdoor workers and unhoused neighbors. Share fit and use caveats. Follow local worker-safety guidance.
- Share AQI alerts via text, social media, and local networks.
- Reschedule outdoor community events when AQI > 150.
- Partner with local libraries, community centers, and faith groups. Work together to extend shelter hours.

When to seek medical help

- Difficulty breathing or shortness of breath
- Persistent cough, especially with phlegm or blood
- Chest pain or tightness
- Wheezing that does not improve with medication
- Dizziness or confusion
- Palpitations or irregular heartbeat

Key resources

- **AirNow.gov** — Real-time AQI and fire maps (U.S.)
- **Fire and Smoke Map** — fire.airnow.gov
- **EPA Wildfire Smoke Guide** — epa.gov/pm-pollution/wildfire-smoke-guide-factsheets
- **Corsi-Rosenthal Box build guides** — cleanaircrew.org
- **Emergency** — 911 (U.S./Canada), 112 (Europe), 999 (UK)

Sources include:

- AirNow — wildfire smoke and air quality information.
- U.S. Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) — wildfire smoke and health guidance.
- U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) — wildfire smoke and health.
- U.S. National Weather Service — wildfire safety.
- Published research and public guidance on DIY air filtration. Verify device-building instructions against current safety guidance before use.

This guide is for educational purposes and does not replace professional medical advice. In an emergency, call your local emergency number.